

Service beyond the status quo: the ripple effect of corporate social responsibility and internal marketing on employee's customer-oriented behavior

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Abstract

Purpose – This paper proposes a research model in which work engagement (WE) mediates the effects of corporate social responsibility (CSR) and internal marketing (IM) simultaneously on customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior (COBSB).

Design/methodology/approach – The study deploys structural equation modeling (SEM) to examine data acquired from 355 frontline bank employees (FBE) of private banks.

Findings – The findings of this study demonstrate that both FBE's perceptions of CSR and IM are positively related to their WE, proposing that adding CSR practices to existing IM programs is likely to boost anticipated employee work attitudes such as WE, which consecutively increase positive employee job outcomes such as COBSB. This research contributes to the body of knowledge by conceptually and empirically gauging CSR and IM practices simultaneously in the banking sector.

Originality/value – This study contributes to the existing body of knowledge by investigating the relationship between CSR and IM to COBSB via WE in frontline service roles in the retail banking sector.

Keywords Customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviour, Corporate social responsibility, Internal marketing, Work engagement, Frontline employee, Banking industry

Paper type Research paper

Introduction

Globally, increased competition in the service industry has forced institutions to develop ways for differentiating themselves from their competitors. The banking sector, being one of the most thriving sectors in the service industry, plays a critical role in the socio-economic development of many countries, particularly emerging economies (Sarangal and Nargota, 2017). Considering the international financial crisis that began in 2008, the banking sector faced significant restructuring, consequently leading to banks globally exploring (tangible and intangible) resources and competencies (Moliner-Tena *et al.*, 2019). According to van Doorn *et al.* (2010), the management of service-oriented institutions must have long-term plans to facilitate customer retention and growth to ensure financial viability. Karatepe *et al.* (2019) stated that employee attitude and behavior are crucial to an organization's competitiveness and long-term performance. Unfortunately, the advent of the COVID-19 pandemic dampens the mental health, attitudes and behaviors of employees (Jafari *et al.*, 2020; Karatepe *et al.*, 2021; Saydam *et al.*, 2022), making excellent service performance a herculean



task across the service industry. This is because individuals socially distance themselves as a strategy to prevent close interaction and deter the further transmission of COVID-19. Social distancing, which entails fewer interactions and less social space, has been reported to weaken the relationship between service providers and customers (Li *et al.*, 2021). These conditions undermine frontline bank employees' (FBE's) roles as mediators between banks and their customers in tasks, such as responding to customer requests successfully, providing fair solutions to customers' problems and giving suggestions to bank management for service improvement (Gursoy *et al.*, 2019; Karatepe and Aga, 2016). As a result, FBE's capacity to meaningfully contribute to their banks' competitiveness is undercut.

Considering these relative issues associated with the pandemic, saturation and competition in the banking industry, the crucial questions are: How can banks continue to achieve competitive advantage? How can banks induce an environment for employees to go beyond the pandemic status quo in sustaining an advantageous competition?

Extant literature has revealed that in order to stimulate a change in employee behavior, management should create an environment where employees can improve their knowledge and skills, feel supported, empowered and fairly compensated (Karatepe, 2013b; Karatepe *et al.*, 2020a; Lasisi *et al.*, 2020). One of the ways this could be achieved is through internal marketing (IM). IM benefits and adds value to an organization by fostering competitiveness and competencies by motivating, empowering, developing and training its employees (Abzari *et al.*, 2011; Ahmed *et al.*, 2003). IM has been defined as "applying the philosophy and practices of marketing to the people who service the external consumers," with the idea that participation in IM activities may foster employee extra-role engagement (Nazir and Islam, 2020) and customer-oriented behaviors (Kanyurhi and Akonkwa, 2016).

Furthermore, scholars claim that workers who are satisfied with their firm's image as a social responsibility organization will perform better and go above and beyond for customers because they connect with the organization's ethos (Ilkhanizadeh and Karatepe, 2017). Organizations now regard corporate social responsibility (CSR) as a significant corporate strategy to gain a competitive advantage (Cheffi *et al.*, 2021; Laguir *et al.*, 2021). Several scholars have recognized and investigated the significance of CSR activities in the service sector (Waheed *et al.*, 2021; Mogaji *et al.*, 2021; Khan and Sulaiman, 2021; Kim *et al.*, 2020a).

CSR is described as an organization's commitment to optimizing long-term economic, social and environmental well-being via business practices, policies and resources management. Carroll (1979) proposed four aspects of CSR. The economic dimension is stated as the necessity for corporations to be profitable. The legal component takes cognizance of the requirement to follow the rules and guidelines published by governments as the foundation for their operations. Ethical obligations encompass all activities and practices that are demanded or prohibited by members of society, even if they are not legally mandated. Finally, the philanthropical dimension refers to the measures made in response to society's expectation that firms operate responsibly. This encompasses an organization's active participation in activities that increase human welfare.

Although critics have argued that CSR might only make frontline employees "feel good," it is, however, unlikely to significantly motivate and engage employees beyond other motivators such as financial incentives (Hu *et al.*, 2020). Nonetheless, CSR strategies give organizations leverage by satisfying the major interests of organizations' various stakeholders (Fernández-Guadano and Sarria-Pedroza, 2018).

Extant literature has revealed that CSR can provide a distinct competitive edge (Sobhani *et al.*, 2021) and could motivate FBE to engage in customer-oriented and extra-role behaviors (Rahman *et al.*, 2016), considering the challenges posed by the pandemic in service delivery. In literature, such customer-oriented extra-role behaviors have been conceptualized as customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior (COBSB).

Based on social exchange and transformative learning theories, this study set out to investigate overlooked antecedents of COBSB by exploring the effect of CSR and IM on COBSB. Furthermore, we explicate an intervening mechanism through which CSR and IM relate to COBSB by demonstrating the mediating role of work engagement (WE) in the relationships. Scholars have shown that extra-role customer service is a critical performance outcome of WE (Babakus *et al.*, 2017; Karatepe, 2013b; Karatepe and Demir, 2014; Karatepe and Ngeche, 2012). On the other hand, employees with favorable perceptions of employers' CSR practices have reported higher levels of WE (Besieux *et al.*, 2018; Rupp *et al.*, 2018). Besides, IM has been employed as a key driver of WE in the banking sector (Mainardes *et al.*, 2019; Sarangal and Nargota, 2017). This suggests that WE could be a potential common underlying mechanism through which CSR and IM jointly relate to COBSB.

This study makes several contributions to the literature. First, bank management can boost their employees' positive job outcomes by investing in CSR initiatives (e.g. Asante Boadi *et al.*, 2020; De Bruin *et al.*, 2021; Tunio *et al.*, 2021) as well as IM practices (De Bruin *et al.*, 2021; Mainardes *et al.*, 2019). With the increasing number of banks implementing CSR programs, CSR has been considered a prominent concept in academia. However, the majority of CSR studies have focused on "external stakeholders" (customers), and less attention has been paid to "internal stakeholders" (employees) (Bugandwa *et al.*, 2021). Furthermore, except for Kim *et al.* (2016), who conducted research in a casino setting and called for more studies to examine the effects of both CSR and IM on service employees simultaneously, no study has empirically examined the simultaneous effects of both CSR and IM practices on banking employees' job outcomes. Second, although the relevant literature appears to delineate some evidence about CSR, both meta-analysis and systematic review research underline that its consequences are still in their infancy stage (Frerichs and Teichert, 2021; Low and Siegel, 2019) also for IM (Qiu *et al.*, 2021). More importantly, there is still limited literature about the impact of both CSR and IM on employees' job outcomes (e.g. De Bruin *et al.*, 2021; Mazzarolo *et al.*, 2021; Zhao *et al.*, 2022). This is a notable gap because we do not know whether the bank's CSR and IM foster service employees' COBSB. Third, it seems that there are empirical studies supporting the relationship between both IM and CSR on job outcomes (Kim *et al.*, 2016). That is, employees perceiving that the organization provides sufficient support and showing that their organization is active in CSR practices are likely to hold positive job outcomes (Karatepe and Aga, 2016; Asante Boadi *et al.*, 2020). However, what is mysterious is the mechanism or process that may mediate the relationship between IM, CSR and COBSB. As a mediating mechanism, WE links CSR, IM to COBSB.

Conceptual framework

Social exchange theory (SET) proposes that to establish a relationship that is based on confidentiality, trustworthiness and reciprocal obligations, the two parties involved (such as the organization and employees) must adhere to certain rules of exchange (Cropanzano and Mitchell, 2005). When workers establish social ties with their employers, they share social-emotional advantages, strong personal connections and open responsibilities (Saks, 2006).

According to Ilkhanizadeh and Karatepe (2017), CSR investment establishes a duty on the part of the employee to be involved and contribute to the success of the corporation. Extant literature has adopted the SET to establish a positive relationship between employee organizations (Ilkhanizadeh and Karatepe, 2018; Karatepe, 2013a; Karatepe *et al.*, 2020b, c; Meira and Hancer, 2021). The above scholars focused on a different aspect of organizational factors and organizational performance through the lens of SET. The current article adopts an integrative view of SET and transformative learning theory (TLT). According to Mezirow's conceptualization, TLT is a transformative process that involves a shift in three dimensions: psychological, conviction and behavioral (Mezirow, 1991). This theory argues that the transformation takes place via a set of processes that are triggered by experiences and environment, which lead to self-examination. Consequently, these internal processes

evolve to role-related behaviors, skill and competence development, and then reintegrate into life with a new viewpoint. The current research postulated that CSR, IM can be triggers of a transformative change in an employee. Extant literature has deployed the theory in a different context such as leadership, education and so on. This study extends the application of the TLT into explaining organizational and management phenomena, particularly in the banking and IM literature.

Corporate social responsibility and work engagement

Recent research indicates that employees' opinions of their organizations' CSR policies may dramatically increase their WE (Ilkhanizadeh and Karatepe, 2017; Panagopoulos *et al.*, 2016). In several studies, CSR has been shown to dramatically improve positive employee participation within an organization. Farooq *et al.* (2014) stated that CSR fosters two kinds of interaction between employees and organizations. First, the interaction involves employees feeling obligated to accomplish something in exchange for various advantages provided by businesses in addition to economic and legal duties, while the second interaction takes cognizance of employees' reactions. Even if their organization is passively engaging in CSR activities, employees may respond to those efforts positively because they are part of a larger community such as the consumers, society and so on. Gürlek and Tuna (2019) affirm that such interaction through the SET pathway will lead to WE. Albdour and Altarawneh (2012) highlighted the positive association between CSR and WE. Gao *et al.* (2018) also found that CSR practices have a direct and positive effect on WE. Rupp *et al.* (2018) demonstrate the association between workers' assessments of their organization's CSR policies in relation to WE. The authors reveal that WE is higher when employees value independence and individuality, emphasizing the importance of personal and situational elements. CSR has been related to higher levels of WE in several ways. Lee *et al.* (2012) discovered that firms that concentrate on the economic and philanthropic components of CSR bolster trust among their employees, resulting in high WE. Furthermore, Lee *et al.* (2014) discovered that organizational philanthropy action is an antecedent of WE. Lin (2010) stated that economic CSR enhances the involvement of workers when they see the organization's economic success to provide them with secure and sufficient employment and quality of life. Legal CSR decreases the negative impact of fatigue, fear and insecurity on the employee that leads to work disengagement. Ethical CSR inspires and enables workers to act positively with their organization and work.

Despite the extensive research investigating the relationship between CSR and WE, there are only a handful of empirical studies providing support for a potential association between CSR and WE in the banking industry. This study, therefore, advances the literature of this relationship by viewing the relationship between CSR and WE in the context of SET and stakeholders theory. According to SET, bank employees are aware that a range of physical, legal, ethical and psychological activities have been involved and implemented and are obliged to pay off through enhanced WE. Consequently, CSR practices could potentially generate requirements on the part of FBE to be extremely engaged in their work and contribute to the job outcomes and reciprocate with positive attitudinal behaviors. Thus, we argue that CSR positively link to FBE's WE via the SET, which agrees with Jones and Kramar's (2010) claim that when workers get advantages from CSR activities, social exchange dynamics incentivize them to give back to their organization. CSR, according to scholars, enabled employees to identify with their firm and feel supported and appreciated (Lee, 2021). As a result, existing literature has utilized SET to hypothesize CSR and employee behavioral outcomes (Gürlek and Tuna, 2019; Lee, 2021). Hence we propose this hypothesis:

- H1. CSR components (legal, ethical, economical and philanthropic) positively relate to FBE's work engagement.

The mediating role of work engagement

Although there is evidence that IM efforts increase employee performance and attitudes, little research has been conducted to investigate the underlying mechanism that explains the relationship between IM and attitudes and outcomes (Aboramadan *et al.*, 2020; Karatepe *et al.*, 2020c). Furthermore, no consensus has been reached on the relationship between IM practices and employee outcomes (Aboramadan *et al.*, 2020; Miao *et al.*, 2021). Hence, Arasli *et al.* (2020) advocated for further empirical studies on IM practices and the underlining mechanism that describes the link between employee behavioral outcomes and IM practices. The researcher chose WE as an intervening mechanism in our investigation for three reasons. First, as stated by Aboramadan (2020), WE appears to be a direct motivator of performance results and attitudes. Specifically, multiple studies have found WE to be a predictor of employee boundary-crossing behavior (De Regge *et al.*, 2020). Second, WE has been demonstrated as a resultant effect of IM practices and job resources (Karatepe and Aga, 2016). Finally, akin to the SET, employees who demonstrate elevated levels of WE are considered to trust and connect with their company more, and as a result, they exhibit more favorable attitudes (engagement) toward their organization (Saks, 2006). Thus, when the bank implements IM practices successively, bank employees will be more engaged, and they tend to reciprocate through supportive attitude and behavior such as boundary-spanning behaviors (Wang *et al.*, 2021). Extant literature has revealed evidence regarding WE mediating the impact of IM practices or the impacts of job resources on job outcomes. For example, Karadas and Karatepe (2018) delineated evidence pertaining to indirect effects of high-performance work systems on quitting intentions, creative performance and extra-role performance via WE. Arasli *et al.* (2020) demonstrated that WE is a mediator between human resource management practices and employees' commitment. In another study, it was reported that the impact of IM practices on job performance was mediated by WE (Karatepe and Aga, 2016). Given the theoretical and empirical foundations outlined above, and in response to calls for more research into the intervening mechanism between IM practices and employee job outcomes via TLT. According to Mezirow (1991), TLT facilitates a transformative process that results in psychological, conviction and behavioral transformation. The transformative process focuses on how and what employees learn (gain through the training element of MI); learning outcome (acknowledged and encouraged through the compensation dimension of IM); learning opportunity/condition (foster through management support dimension of IM); and partner facilitation/work relationships (facilitated through the communication dimension of IM) (Aboytes and Barth, 2020). As a result of this transformational process, behavioral changes will occur (WE and COBSB) Thus, we posit this hypothesis:

H2. Work engagement mediates the relationship between internal marketing and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors

Limited attempts have been made in the past to discover the underlying mechanisms explaining the connection between CSR practices and employee behaviors (Chaudhary and Akhouri, 2018). The relevant literature delineates studies about the mediating role of WE (Karatepe and Aga, 2016; Aboramadan *et al.*, 2020). WE is generally seen as a motivational mechanism that influences performance outcomes (Kaya and Karatepe, 2020). Again in line with the SET, the study proposes WE as a mediating mechanism between the independent and dependent variables in this research. Broadly speaking, we assert that when employees consider a bank's CSR-related activities and regulations as fair, they exhibit elevated levels of WE and are more inclined to go beyond their official tasks by displaying behaviors that help the entire organization (Farid *et al.*, 2019). Employees with greater levels of WE are more prone to be in quality social exchanges with the employer (Aboramadan, 2020). As a result, employees will display positive outcomes (Saks, 2006), including COBSB. Numerous research studies appear to have handled WE as an intervening variable. For example, Bizri *et al.* (2021)

study in Lebanon reported that WE mediated the impact of CSR on bank employees' job performance. Chaudhary and Akhouri's (2018) study demonstrated that WE serve as a mediator between CSR practices and creativity among information technology employees in India. Ilkhanizadeh and Karatepe's (2017) study conducted among flight attendants showed that CSR influenced flight attendants' career satisfaction and voice behavior indirectly via WE. Moreover, Gupta's (2017) study confirms the presence of partial mediation by WE in between CSR and organizational commitment among information technology employees in India. In this study, we propose that bank employees' favorable perceptions of CSR practices positively influence WE, which, in turn, engenders COBSB. As previously stated, although several studies have delineated the mediating role of WE using a variety of variables, none have investigated WE as a mediator of the effects of CSR practices on COBSB among bank employees (see Figure 1). Based on the above arguments, we hypothesize the following:

H3. Work engagement mediates the relation between CSR perceptions and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behavior.

Methodology and analysis

Sample and procedure

Data were obtained from FBE of private banks in Nigeria in the summer of 2020. There are 23 commercial banks in Nigeria (Ogunmokun and Timur, 2021). Branches of all the banks were considered in the data collection process. Managers were contacted and informed about the study. Although they consented to participate, they did not allow the researcher to speak with the staff directly due to the heightened pandemic restrictions. Instead, the researcher coordinated the data collection process through liaisons with representatives appointed by the managers. Representatives from each participating bank were asked to disseminate the questionnaires to a varied set of customer-contact personnel to reduce the possibility of selection bias.

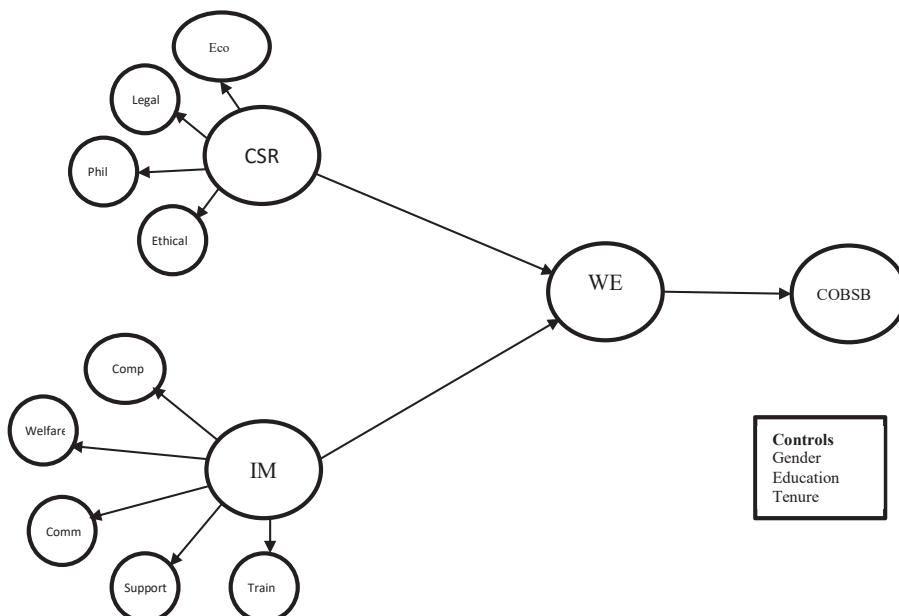


Figure 1.
Model

Common method bias: procedural remedies

To reduce the possible common method bias, we utilized a few practical steps. First, the questionnaires' cover page associated with each survey guaranteed participants that the survey was unidentified and anonymous. This would maintain the confidentiality of the data. Second, filled questionnaires were collected in closed and sealed envelopes to be able to avoid common method variance. Third, the cover page noted that "there are no correct or incorrect responses to the questionnaire's items." Fourth, we reported that participation in this study was voluntary, and cooperation was obtained from selected representatives who were the bank workers. Fifth, since rates were divided into two – self-rate and superior-rate – data were collected from bank workers in two-time lag divided by a three-week time lag along with their direct superiors.

Furthermore, steps that we took in the data collection period were consistent with procedures described by Podsakoff *et al.* (2012) during the survey development and data collection procedures. CSR practices, which are economic, legal, ethical and philanthropic components, (Time 1 survey) were used to measure CSR on a wide-ranging assessment of the existing literature and managerial practices of the most important companies in service settings (e.g. Kim *et al.*, 2020b). For measuring CSR (Time 1), Carroll (1979) and (Lee, 2020) items were adopted for this study. The economic component of CSR was measured using three items, and the philanthropic component was measured with four items. The legal component of CSR was measured with four items. The ethical component of CSR was operationalized with two items. IM components (Time 1) were measured by adapting from different studies. Welfare systems were adapted from Back *et al.*' (2011) research and four items were selected. Management supports was adapted from (Kohli *et al.*, 1993) and three items were selected. Communication was adapted from Back *et al.* (2011), and three items were used. Compensation was adapted from Foreman and Money's (1995) study, and three items were adopted for measuring compensation. Items used to measure training were adapted from Back *et al.* (2011). Each item was given a score ranging from 5 (strongly agree) to 1 (strongly disagree). The WE scale was employed in this study (Time 2 survey). This scale contained nine questions (Schaufeli *et al.*, 2006), and answers were recorded with anchors at 6 (always) and 0 (never). COBSB was measured using nine items in our study (Time 2). These components have been adopted from Bettencourt *et al.* (2005).

A total of 355 completed surveys were obtained from the data collection process. The demographics of the study sample are detailed in Table 1.

Preliminary first-order analysis

A factor analysis of all first-order constructs was carried out for all the 11 factors (4 CSR factors, 5 IM factors, WE and COBSB). As reported in Appendix, all 11 factors significantly loaded to their respective constructs. The confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) likewise

Table 1.
Demographics of
respondents

Variable		Frequency (<i>n</i> = 355)	Percentage
Age	18–28 years	93	26.2
	29–39 years	174	49.0
	40–50 years	87	24.5
Gender	Female	169	47.6
	Male	186	52.6
	Non-binary	0	0
Marital status	Single	117	33.0
	Married	238	67.0
Education	Postgraduate degree	146	41.1
	BSc degree	209	58.9

revealed a good fit: $\chi^2 = 2.467$, CFI = 0.949, IFI = 0.950, TLI = 0.944, RMSEA = 0.064. The correlations and validities of all factors were also satisfactory (see Table 2).

Second-order factor models offer a more parsimonious and interpretable framework with fewer constructs (Rindskopf and Rose, 1988). However, before second-order CSR and IM were adopted in this study, alternative models were compared to confirm that the four and five first-order factors of CSR and IM were respectively the best fit. This comparison was first conducted for CSR. The first model (M1) shows all first-order items loading on the legal dimension of CSR. In the second model (M2), items for the legal dimension were loaded on their respective dimension, but the remaining items were all loaded on the philanthropic dimension of CSR. In the third model (M3), the items for the legal and philanthropic dimensions were loaded on their respective dimensions, and the remaining two items were loaded on the economic dimension of CSR. In the fourth model (M4), all items were loaded to their respective dimension. The same process was repeated for IM; the first model (M1) is all first-order items loading on the welfare dimension of IM. In the second model (M2), items for the welfare dimension were loaded on their respective dimension, but the remaining items were all loaded on the training dimension of IM. In the third model (M3), the items for the welfare and training dimensions were loaded on their respective dimensions, and the remaining items were loaded on the compensation dimension of IM. In the fourth model (M4), items for the welfare, training and compensation were loaded on their respective dimensions to their respective dimension, and the remaining items were loaded on the communication dimension of IM. In the fifth model (M5), all items were loaded to their respective dimension (see Table 3).

As reported in Table 3, since the factors of IM and CSR showed a better fit in models M5 and M4, we confirm that the best fit is a multidimensional reflective second-order IM and CSR with 4 and 5 first-order dimensions, respectively. We utilized an overall measure of IM and CSR, as suggested by Koufteros *et al.* (2009) and Nunkoo *et al.* (2017). To establish the total measure of IM and CSR, a two-step technique was used. The scores of the first-order constructs were calculated in the first phase using the data imputation function in AMOS 24. The scores of the first-order constructs were then employed as indications of the second-order IM and CSR in the second stage.

Measurement model

The study data's normality distribution (skewness and kurtosis) is within the required range of -3 to $+3$. The value of skewness ranged from -0.047 to -1.735 and the values of kurtosis from 2.255 to -0.836 . The factorial validity evaluation of the measurement instruments was carried out with CFA using AMOS 24. CFA was employed to assess the study's measurement model consisting of CSR (along with its four dimensions – economics, philanthropic, ethics and legal), IM (along with its five dimensions – training, compensation, management support, compassion and welfare), WE and COBSB. The proposed four-factor model (COBSB, WE and reflective second-order factor of IM and CSR) showed a satisfactory fit to the data: $\chi^2 [1019] = 2496.057$, $\chi^2/\text{df} = 2.450$, CFI = 0.948, TLI = 0.948, SRMR = 0.068, RMSEA = 0.064. Additionally, the constructs revealed satisfactory levels of convergent and discriminant validities and internal consistency (see Table 4). This is except for CSR with AVE = 0.495. Earlier studies in the banking sector have reported AVE values below the threshold of 0.5 (e.g. Çop *et al.*, 2021; Karatepe *et al.*, 2019). An AVE value below 0.5 is still adequate. So far, the variable's composite reliability is satisfactory, which is the case in this study. Thus, validities do not seem to be an issue.

Endogeneity test

Endogeneity can cause regression estimates to be skewed in such a way that causation between independent and dependent variables is assumed even when such linkages do not

Table 2.
Correlation, reliability
and validity

	CR	AVE	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
WE	0.977	0.831	<i>0.911</i>										
COBSB	0.980	0.862	-0.026	<i>0.928</i>									
Welfare IM	0.966	0.876	-0.004	0.057	<i>0.936</i>								
Legal CSR	0.958	0.852	-0.038	0.030	0.102 [†]	<i>0.948</i>							
Communication IM	0.966	0.903	0.050	0.030	0.371 ^{***}	0.014 ^{***}	<i>0.950</i>						
Philanthropic CSR	0.864	0.627	-0.029	0.018	0.536 ^{***}	0.225 ^{***}	0.212 ^{***}	<i>0.792</i>					
Support IM	0.885	0.725	0.008	0.050	0.418 ^{***}	0.055 ^{***}	0.243 ^{***}	0.460 ^{***}	<i>0.852</i>				
Economic CSR	0.809	0.589	0.023	0.021	0.199 ^{***}	0.048 ^{***}	0.208 ^{***}	0.341 ^{***}	0.338 ^{***}	<i>0.767</i>			
Ethics CSR	0.768	0.625	0.010	0.043	0.474 ^{***}	0.219 ^{***}	0.308 ^{***}	0.605 ^{***}	0.348 ^{***}	0.688 ^{***}	<i>0.791</i>		
Training IM	0.884	0.720	0.012	-0.011	0.611 ^{***}	-0.125 [*]	0.369 ^{***}	0.466 ^{***}	0.396 ^{***}	0.292 ^{***}	0.485 ^{***}	<i>0.849</i>	
Compensation IM	0.865	0.682	0.038	0.064	0.702 ^{***}	0.103 [†]	0.467 ^{***}	0.653 ^{***}	0.546 ^{***}	0.248 ^{***}	0.702 ^{***}	0.611 ^{***}	<i>0.826</i>
Note(s): Square roots of AVEs are italic in the diagonal; *** $p < 0.0001$; ** $p < 0.001$; * $p < 0.05$; [†] $p < 0.10$													

exist. Endogeneity arises when explanatory variables are correlated to the error terms as a result of simultaneous causality, omitted variables, or errors in variables (Zaefarian *et al.*, 2017). Following Nwoba *et al.*'s (2021) adoption of Hamilton and Nickerson (2003) and Poppo *et al.* (2016), endogeneity bias test was conducted using a three-stage least squares regression analysis. This further analysis is conducted to eliminate potential endogeneity bias as WE could be endogenous in the study's model.

In Stage 1, the study regressed WE on CSR and IM, saving the unstandardized residuals. In Stage 2, the main effect of WE on COBSB was tested by regressing COBSB on WE residual and the control variables. The Stage 3 model regressed COBSB on WE residual, CSR, IM and the study's controls variables to determine the mediating effect of WE residual. Results show that the link from the residuals of WE to COBSB is significant at 5%. It also revealed that the CSR–COBSB and IM–COBSB links are (partially) mediated by WE residual at 1%. These findings are consistent with those obtained from the prior SEM analysis. For this reason, the study's findings do not seem to be undermined by endogeneity bias.

Hypotheses testing

Once the measurement model is evaluated, structural equation modeling (SEM) was employed to test the hypothesized relationships among the variables in the study's proposed model. The SEM result showed a good fit: $\chi^2[4] = 5.704$, $\chi^2/\text{df} = 1.426$, $p = 0.222$, CFI = 0.98, IFI = 0.98, TLI = 0.97, PClose = 0.588, SRMR = 0.021 and RMSEA = 0.035. Because education, gender and tenure (the total number of years an employee has worked in the organization) can affect the study's variables, they were controlled for in the SEM analysis (Bayighomog and Arashi, 2019b).

An examination of the path estimates shows that employees' perceptions of their organization's CSR have a significant direct relationship with their WE ($\beta = 0.23$, $p < 0.05$), supporting hypothesis 1. Using AMOS vs. 25 (5,000 bootstrapping), the study's mediation hypotheses were tested. WE significantly mediates the relationship between IM and COBSB ($\beta = 0.025$; 95%CI[0.004, 0.093]), as well as the relationship between CSR and COBSB ($\beta = 0.023$; 95%CI[0.005, 0.057]). Thus hypotheses 2 and 3 are supported, respectively (see Figure 2).

Constructs	Model	CMIN	df	χ^2/df	IFI	CFI	TLI	RMSEA
CSR	M1	1982.67	62	31.98	0.567	0.566	0.454	0.296
	M2	864.586	61	14.17	0.819	0.818	0.768	0.193
	M3	461.445	59	7.82	0.909	0.909	0.880	0.139
	M4	164.117	52	3.156	0.975	0.975	0.962	0.078
Internal marketing	M1	4952.06	101	49.03	0.516	0.515	0.424	0.368
	M2	3737.90	100	37.38	0.637	0.636	0.563	0.321
	M3	1735.86	98	17.71	0.837	0.836	0.799	0.217
	M4	724.40	95	7.625	0.937	0.937	0.920	0.137
	M5	338.49	91	3.72	0.975	0.975	0.977	0.068

Table 3.
First order validity
measurement

	Mean	SD	CR	AVE	1	2	3	4
1. Work engagement	2.92	0.99	0.979	0.843	<i>0.918</i>			
2. COBSB	3.63	0.71	0.978	0.832	0.025***	<i>0.912</i>		
3. Internal marketing	3.85	0.07	0.826	0.514	0.029*	0.034***	<i>0.717</i>	
4. CSR	4.19	0.50	0.792	<i>0.494</i>	0.006*	0.057***	0.38***	<i>0.703</i>

Note(s): Square roots of AVEs are in italics on the diagonals (*** $p < 0.000$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$)

Table 4.
Descriptive statistics
and correlations of
observed variables

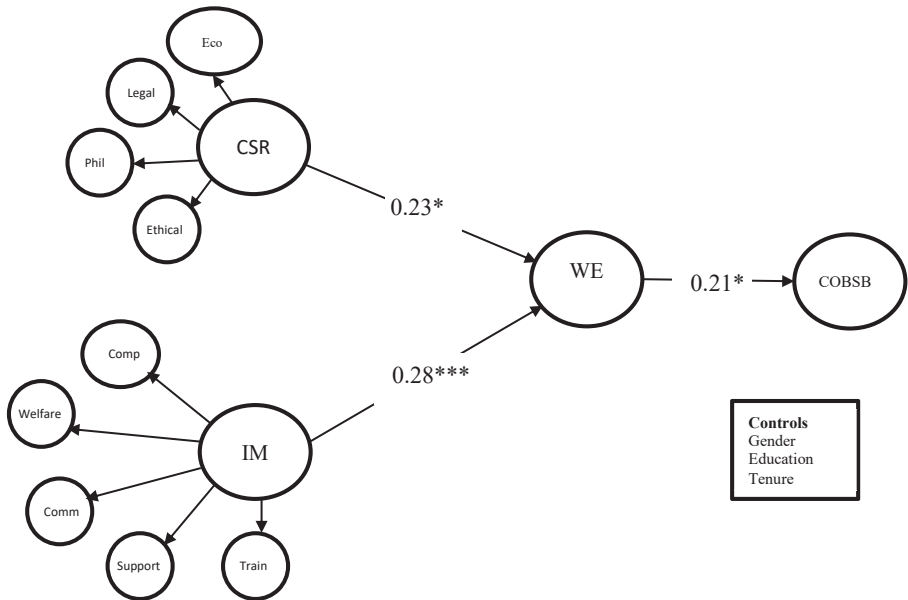


Figure 2.
Model with coefficient

Discussion and implications

Discussion

The study evaluated three hypotheses investigating the nexus among IM, CSR, WE and COBSB using data collected from Nigerian bank personnel. The findings provide empirical evidence supporting all posited hypotheses. CSR components, in general, together with MI enhance bank employees' WE and COBSB. Based on the SET, bank employees reciprocate employers' goodwill with WE at high levels, and this has been confirmed in this study and other related research studies (Karatepe *et al.*, 2020c; Ilkhanizadeh and Karatepe, 2017). When bank employees consider their organizations' CSR investments and the resulting trustworthiness and high-quality stakeholder relationships, they are energized and motivated to work. Through this, they can yield more positive job outcomes, such as COBSBs. Theoretically, these findings concur with earlier CSR scholastic research (e.g. Boğan and Dedeoğlu, 2020; Choi *et al.*, 2020; Ilkhanizadeh and Karatepe, 2017), adding to the growing body of studies on CSR and employee attitudes at work.

This study supports the posited conceptualization of multidimensional IM in bank marketing studies. The research shows that the suggested five components of IM (compensation, welfare systems, training, management support and communication) correctly reflect the multifaceted framework of IM in the banking sector. Furthermore, the result of this existing study depicts that IM has a favorable impact on WE, which supports prior research findings (e.g. Karatepe and Aga, 2016; Al-Weshah, 2019). The current study provides the first empirical evidence of a positive association between IM and WE in a banking setting, as none of the prior research had empirically assessed the link between IM and WE in a banking scenario. Furthermore, this research suggests that bank employees' higher levels of CSR and IM boost their COBSBs. Additionally, WE acted as an intervening variable between CSR, IM and COBSB. Although researchers have gauged the importance of employees' WE in increasing employees' positive job outcomes (e.g. Karatepe *et al.*, 2019; Gupta *et al.*, 2017; Ng *et al.*, 2019), none of these studies examined such links experimentally by adding both CSR and IM simultaneously as determinants of WE.

This study demonstrates that with well-executed IM and CSR activities, banking managers and decision-makers may strengthen their employees' WE, which can lead to increased COBSBs of their employees.

Theoretical implications

Firstly, current research enhances the body of knowledge in the extant service research by gauging WE as an intervening variable of the impacts of IM and CSR simultaneously on banking employees' COBSB. Specifically, current research responds to the call for more study regarding the factors which has an impact on the bank employees' WE (Karatepe *et al.*, 2019; Rai and Maheshwari, 2020). Our study heeds the call and extends the stream of research by gauging the concurrent effects of IM and CSR on FBE's WE.

Secondly, this study extends the literature by investigating the mediating role of WE in the relationship between CSR–COBSB and IM–COBSB. Consequently, the study broadens understanding by identifying underlying mechanisms involved in enhancing customer-oriented behavioral results through a motivational WE. Thirdly, our study extends the service marketing field of study and specifically the boundary-spanning and WE literature by assessing employee COBSBs within the framework of a CSR and IM simultaneously under the umbrella of SET and TLT for the first time. Earlier studies have ignored this stream of study, predominantly in the banking sector. We hypothesized and found support for the positive effect of both CSR and IM on employees' COBSB. This is important since scholars have demonstrated such a void in the relevant literature (Karatepe *et al.*, 2019; Kim *et al.*, 2016).

Finally, the investigations contribute theoretically to the extant literature by illustrating the transformational process of bank personnel using TLT. TLT entails gaining a larger understanding of the world, as well as cultivating innovative capacities and capabilities under new settings (Soulard *et al.*, 2019). The uncertainty induced by the COVID 19 pandemic and the increased intensity of competition in the banking industry act as a trigger for employees to engage in self-examination. As a result, these internal processes progress to the development of role-related behaviors, skills and competencies, with the aid of the organization's IM and CSR efforts. Consequently, this study advances the literature by highlighting the transformative process of banking employees in engaging in better work-related behavior (COBSB) via TLT.

Practical implications

The current study has practical implications for banking managers. Firstly, COBSBs among employees are somewhat comparable to organizational citizenship behavior in terms of benevolence beyond formal standards. These are social capital assets that can help a company outperform its competition. Thus, managers would be wise to invest in such assets for their organizations. Because frontline staff with strong COBSBs will provide an outstanding service experience to customers (Bayighomog and Arasli, 2019a), do their jobs pro-actively and promptly communicate with colleagues about critical workflow and service information. This effect can be amplified if employees believe their employer is committed to human resource practices. Broadly speaking, managers of banking organizations should rethink their IM strategy as it is important to customer-oriented behaviors during the pandemic. IM should be seen as a strategy for informing staff, bringing them closer to the bank and ensuring that the bank's vision and image are maintained in the eyes of the employees as the banks' internal customers. In addition, as part of IM, banks should respond quickly to employee requests, demonstrate a willingness to assist them, give numerous opportunities for education and training and provide timely and positive feedback.

Likewise, because employees often oblige to fulfill their managers' ideas and concerns, in the face of the challenges imposed by the pandemic on quality service delivery, managers should emphasize and appreciate the display of customer-oriented behaviors that circumvents the challenges to deliver sustained quality service. This may be achieved by encouraging employees to engage in customer-focused activities by allowing them greater autonomy in dealing with consumers and educating them to be more proficient in doing so through IM. Also, to inspire staff to display COBSBs that beat service delivery bottlenecks, progressive compensation systems must be devised that reflect explicit criteria linked to customer satisfaction and customer relationship promotion. Managers must also provide service staff sufficient discretion, which instills more trust in their ability to address clients' demands. Managers are also urged to focus on both IM techniques and customer service quality orientation at the same time to maximize employees' engagement in their employment.

Secondly, organizations should communicate CSR programs to employees (both formally and informally) and actively foster an environment where employees may participate in the formulation, implementation and assessment of CSR activities. This may help workers perceive more CSR initiatives and, as a result, increase their engagement. Employees are more likely to be engaged if they view the significance and value of their job as stemming from their organization's CSR efforts. CSR activities increase employee engagement by increasing the meaningfulness of workers' jobs. Bank managers should place a higher premium on meaningful work by participating in training programs focused on creating and executing CSR initiatives addressing social and environmental challenges.

Thirdly, the majority of prior research examined the association between IM and job outcomes. However, the literature indicates that research on the association between IM and WE is scarce (Yildiz, 2016). Bank executives should revisit their IM approach in terms of both employee development and retention. IM can be employed to educate staff, connect them to the bank and guarantee that they can uphold the bank's mission and image with customers. Additionally, managers must enhance the service quality of internal services by developing workers' abilities; this results in increased customer satisfaction and, consequently, staff engagement. According to the study's findings, relationship marketing may be used to develop long-term, mutually beneficial connections with internal stakeholders such as workers. Therefore, to accomplish relationship marketing, information management concepts must be implemented in this manner, not just as a tool for objectifying personnel but also as a strategy for engaging employees in interactive interactions that incorporate individual and organizational goals. This research claims that IM can assist bank management in identifying the bank's most successful techniques for developing and empowering employees' talents.

Last but not least, bank managers may boost both the high (growth needs) and low (basic requirements) demands of their employees by adopting appealing CSR methods. Managers, for example, should consider introducing volunteer CSR activities to address workers' higher-end requirements for self-esteem, self-actualization and education. Managers are also encouraged to consider their workers' job titles while developing CSR policies (Bibi *et al.*, 2021). According to the literature, lower-level employees are more concerned with their fundamental requirements, but upper-level employees are more concerned with their position, welfare, renown and contribution to society at large (Kim *et al.*, 2020b). Employees' CSR needs at various levels are important for banks because of their service-based nature; hence, personalized CSR activities according to employees' positions can increase happiness and ensure organizational success (Bibi *et al.*, 2021).

Limitation and further research

The current study has a few limitations. First, CSR and IM components were assessed based on employee impressions of their bank's CSR and IM initiatives, which may or may not be

accurate. Before distributing surveys to employees, future research may seek to conduct training or orientation on the subject firms' CSR and IM activities.

Secondly, the study data were drawn from frontline employees working in Nigerian banks. As a result, the findings may not be generalizable to banking employees in other jurisdictions (Ogunmokun *et al.*, 2021). Further research could collect data from multiple sources (supervisor) and more than one country to improve the generalizability.

Finally, future research could investigate similar relationships employing cross-national data (e.g. China, India, or the USA) to cross-validate bank employees' perceptions of CSR and IM and their effects on various work outcomes (e.g. organizational citizenship behavior, voice behavior, or knowledge sharing behavior) in different nations. Finally, similar and extended studies in other service environments such as restaurants, casinos, or aviation would contribute to the knowledge on CSR, IM and COBSB.

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Variables	Loadings
<i>CSR $\alpha = 0.858$</i>	
<i>Economic CSR</i>	
Our bank strives to reduce operational expenses	0.863
Our bank attempts to increase staff productivity	0.773
Our bank develops a long-term economic growth plan	0.651
<i>Ethical CSR</i>	
Our bank strives to become an ethically trustworthy organization	0.713
Our bank has ethics guidelines on business activities	0.861
<i>Legal CSR</i>	
Our bank has agreed to a legal contract related to commercial operations	0.896
Our bank establishes the proper operating procedures and guidelines for consumers	0.966
Our bank abides by labor regulations (hiring and employee benefits)	0.964
Our bank abides by business regulations	0.862
<i>Philanthropic CSR</i>	
Our bank is dedicated to making the community a better place	0.936
Our bank provides several public services through its Cultural and Welfare Foundations	0.975
Our bank takes involved in a wide range of voluntary activities	0.644
Our bank provides a variety of donations	0.518
<i>Internal marketing $\alpha = 0.942$</i>	
<i>Management supports</i>	
Our bank's management promotes two-way information exchange across management levels	0.907
The management of our bank offers guidance in solving job-related problems	0.973
The bank's management promotes open communication	0.637
<i>Welfare systems</i>	
Our bank provides excellent welfare services	0.898
Our bank provides excellent vacation systems	0.931
Our bank provides excellent employee benefits	0.964
Our company has an excellent structure in place for employees to take a leave of absence	0.949
<i>Compensation</i>	
Our bank determines my pay based on my performance	0.780
This bank adequately compensates for employee performance	0.909
Employees that create strong relationships with consumers are recognized for their efforts in this bank	0.782
<i>Training</i>	
There are enough training programs in this bank	0.891
Training sessions in this bank help me to understand customers need	0.909
This bank provides regular service training	0.735
<i>Communication</i>	
In this bank, I can express my opinions freely in a liberal atmosphere	0.898
The exchange of information in our bank is adequate	0.975
Our bank provides adequate information on the requirements of my job	0.976

Table A1.
Factor loadings

(continued)

Variables	Loadings	Customer-oriented boundary- spanning behavior
<i>COBSB- Employees of this organization . . . $\alpha = 0.972$</i>		
Tell outsiders this is a great place to work	0.912	
Generate favorable goodwill for this organization	0.909	
Says good things about this organization to others	0.956	
Make constructive suggestions for service improvements	0.940	
Share creative solutions to customer problems with other teams	0.947	
Encourage other coworkers to contribute ideas and suggestions for service improvement	–	
Follow up promptly to customer requests and problems	0.941	
Regardless of circumstances are exceptionally courteous and respectful to customers	0.937	
Follow-through in a conscientious manner on promises to customers	0.881	
<i>Work engagement $\alpha = 0.976$</i>		
At my work, I feel bursting with energy	0.889	
At my job, I feel strong and vigorous	0.973	
I am enthusiastic about my job	0.966	
My job inspires me	0.953	
When I get up in the morning, I feel like going to work	0.952	
I feel happy when I am working intensely	0.952	
I am proud of the work that I do	0.947	
I am immersed in my work	0.944	
I get carried away when I am working	0.545	
Note(s): – = items dropped due to poor loading, α = Cronbach alpha values		841

Table A1.

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